Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

May 2024

WHERE ARTISTRY MEETS CLAY



India is a treasure house of diverse pottery traditions. Each region, with its unique soil, climate, water and air, presents a different character of the craft. Here are a few interesting examples.

Khurja Pottery

Gleaming by design



Unlike traditional clay pottery, this craft of U.P. uses a mix of clay and naturally occurring crystalline materials. These two substances add a pleasing glaze to the clay even before the article is moulded. A myriad bright creations, in shaded colours or embellished with floral patterns, have found worldwide markets.

Jaipur Blue Pottery

No clay!

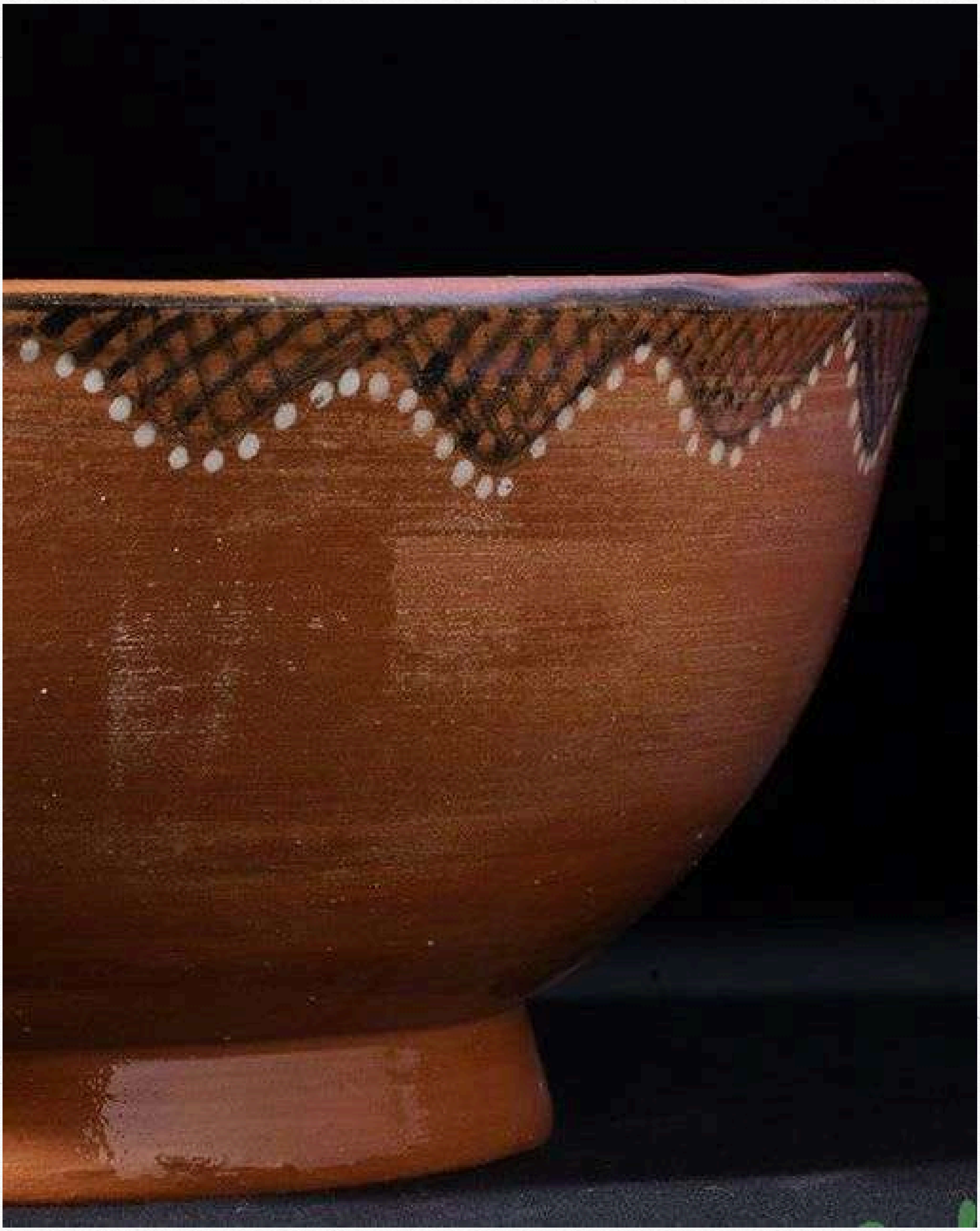


The ‘dough’ for this bright and brilliant pottery is prepared by mixing quartz powder, powdered glass, Fuller’s earth (Multani mitti), borax, gum and water. The colours are predominantly blues, derived from a cobalt dye, though touches of white, green, red, yellow and even brown are often included.

The designs point to Mughal, Persian and Turkish influences, seen in the characteristic patterns and the use of motifs from nature.



Khavda Pottery, Gujarat
An Indus Valley legacy



In the small village of Khavda, at the rim of the Rann of Kutch, generations of craftsmen have been making earthenware in much the same way as their ancestors of Harappan times. Astonishing but true.

The mud for this form of pottery is obtained from a lake nearby and is popularly referred to as “Rann ki mitti”.

The artisans of Khavda shape it into forms that combine utility and beauty. Once the pots are sunned and baked, the womenfolk adorn them with delicate motifs in primal, earthy hues.



When you hold a piece of Khavda pottery you probably hold a 4000-year-old piece of history.

Nizamabad Black Clay Pottery, U.P.
Engraved like metal



Craftsmen here mold the local velvety black clay into classic forms. The distinctive colour is deepened by the smoke of smouldering rice husks in the baking kiln.

A steel needle is then used to make fine, indented patterns on the surface. These are deftly filled with an alloy of zinc, lead and mercury, resulting in an exquisite silvery interplay with the intense black. A quick coat of lacquer provides a glossy finish.

Hard to believe that the richly decorated final product is just a clay pot!

Manamadurai Pottery of Sivagangai, Tamil Nadu
A protocol for perfection



The Vaigai river, which flows through the village of Manamadurai, enriches the clay used for making the pottery. Natural elements such as lead, graphite, calcium lime, sodium silicate and iron are added to a clay-water mixture, which is left in the hot sun for two days. Sifted river sand is finally added to the slurry to obtain the right moulding consistency. The proportions of the circumference, neck and bottom of the pots are also strictly defined.



The manner in which the five natural elements of earth, water, fire, sun and air uniquely come together to create these unglazed pots won them a well-deserved GI tag in 2023.

Longpi (also Nungbi) pottery, Manipur
No potter's wheel here



Tribal craftsmen combine ground black serpentine stone with a special brown clay, to mould by hand a variety of pots and utensils for everyday use. The articles are then sun-dried and heated in a bonfire. A final polish with a special local leaf imparts a soft lustre.



Devoid of embellishments, Longpi cookware is beautiful in its simplicity. That along with its sturdy shapes and ability to retain heat, have made it popular well beyond Manipur, encouraging the younger generation of potters to persist with the craft. A rare phenomenon in the Indian handicrafts community.

Studio pottery
Across urban India



Meanwhile, an exciting new world of pottery is opening its doors across the country.







While respecting traditional techniques, contemporary potters are experimenting with forms, glazes and firing methods; with an unwavering eye on eco-friendly practices at every stage of the making.